pushed me into interpreting that statement. Here is a precis of what I told them.

At the heart of the existentialist philosophy is the premise that all existence is absurd. Life has no meaning and death is the ultimate absurdity. But in the course of this absurd existence, man is forced to make choices, even if those choices may be about absurd issues. But man abhors this freedom of choice, a condition called ‘existential angst’. Until we reach a time when most of our life lies behind us, we second-guess ourselves interminably. ‘What if I had done this?’ ‘What if I had done that?’ ‘Could I have learnt from what others before me have done?’ But that is a futile endeavour. It is just not possible to pass on the burden of decision-making to someone else, nor is it possible to learn from other’s experiences. Every man has to make choices by falling back on his own experience. In short, man is condemned to be free.

I must admit it didn’t exactly go as fluently as that, and to this day I wonder if the wise men (yes, all men, no woman!) on the board were impressed or put off by a cocky twenty-two-year-old pontificating on what is arguably one of the most abstract concepts in the history of ideas.

But why did this memory from over forty years ago come to me when I am thinking about what I would have done differently as governor of the Reserve Bank? Perhaps to remind me that every governor is a creature of the circumstances in which he is called upon to perform. He has to make choices and decisions based on his own learning and experiences. The governor is condemned to be free!

If there was another chance, I could fall back on this experience to do things differently. But then there are no second chances in life.

Looking Ahead

Another omnibus question that I have been asked both while on the job as governor, and after I stepped down, is about the challenges for the Reserve Bank on the way forward. I will highlight, but only briefly, four challenges